



ARGUMENT • BEHAVIOURAL DESIGN

Attention Is the Scarce Resource

What shoppers who touch and look at products teach us about every behaviour we try to change, from checkout pages to shop floors.

IN BRIEF

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Retail research has shown for two decades that customers who look at and handle a product are far more likely to buy it. The usual explanation is psychological ownership: touching makes something feel like yours. This paper argues that the deeper mechanism is attention, and that attention is the recurring, scarce resource behind almost every behaviour-change problem, whether the goal is a purchase in a shop, a conversion on a website, or a new habit in an organisation. If you cannot get attention, nothing downstream happens. If you spend it carelessly, nothing downstream survives.

1. A shop-floor finding with a much larger meaning

Put a customer within arm's reach of a product, let them pick it up, and the odds of a sale go up. Field and lab work in consumer psychology has repeated this result in many forms. Peck and Shu showed that merely touching an object raises the sense that it is already yours, and that this perceived ownership raises what people are willing to pay (Peck & Shu, 2009). Hultén's field experiment in IKEA's glassware department found that adding visual and olfactory cues at the point of purchase changed how much shoppers touched the products, with corresponding differences in sales (Hultén, 2012). Streicher, Estes and Büttner showed that widening shoppers' breadth of attention triggers an exploratory mindset that increases both physical exploration and unplanned purchases (Streicher, Estes & Büttner, 2021). Retail researchers at the University of Bath have argued for taking eye tracking out of the lab and into real stores precisely because where the eyes go is the best available proxy for where the decision goes (Journal of Retailing, 2024).

The retail interpretation of these findings is tactical: unbox the product, remove the "do not touch" sign, lower the shelf, add a sensory cue. That is fine advice, and retailers should follow it. But if we stop there we miss the general lesson.

Looking and touching are not the cause of the purchase. They are the visible trace of a resource being spent: attention. The purchase follows the attention, not the fingertips.

Once you see it that way, the shop floor and the checkout page and the corporate change programme become the same problem in different clothes.

2. Why attention, not touch, is the mechanism

Consider what has to happen inside a person for touch to matter. First the product must enter the visual field. Then it must win against everything else competing for the eyes: other products, a phone, a partner, a child, the exit sign. Only once it has been selected for processing can a hand

reach for it. Touch then extends and deepens that processing: it adds haptic information, it lengthens dwell time, and it gives the imagination something concrete to work with. Perceived ownership is what a few extra seconds of concentrated attention feel like from the inside.

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Three properties of attention make it the right frame for behavioural design:

- **It is finite and rivalrous.** A second spent on one object is not spent on another. This is why retail shelf position is an auction, why ad impressions are priced, and why the notification on a phone is the most powerful competitor any in-store display has.
- **It is the gate to every later step.** Motivation, ability and intention cannot act on something that was never noticed. Every behaviour model, from COM-B to Fogg's B=MAP, silently assumes the person is already attending to the cue.
- **It is cheaply lost and expensively regained.** A shopper who has walked past the display is gone. A visitor who bounced from a landing page is gone. A manager whose inbox swallowed the change announcement is gone. Winning back the same person costs far more than holding them the first time.

3. The same problem in digital conversion

Translate the retail finding to a website and it reads: users who look at and interact with the product are more likely to buy it. Nobody in e-commerce would dispute this. Image galleries, 360-degree views, configurators, size guides, augmented-reality "see it in your room" features and interactive demos are all attempts to buy back what the screen took away: the possibility of touch. The best of them work because they extend dwell time and concentrate attention, not because a rendered sofa can be felt.

But digital settings also show the failure mode more clearly than shops do. Attention is spent before it reaches the product. It is spent on cookie banners, pop-ups, carousels, nine-item navigation menus, chat widgets and "sign up for 10% off" overlays. Each one is defensible on its own. Together they are the retail equivalent of placing the product behind a queue of people handing out leaflets. The visitor's attention budget was consumed by the store, not by the merchandise.

DIAGNOSTIC QUESTION

By the time a visitor can see the thing you want them to act on, how much of their attention have you already spent on things you do not care about?

4. The same problem in organisational change

Now translate it again. Employees who look at and handle a new way of working are more likely to adopt it. This too is obviously true and is routinely ignored. Change programmes are announced in an email, presented in a town hall, and stored in an intranet page. Attention is assumed rather than

earned. Meanwhile the new system, process or behaviour is never placed within arm's reach of the person expected to use it. It is not visible at the moment of the old habit. It cannot be picked up and tried without consequence.

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The organisations that succeed at change do the equivalent of unboxing the product. They put the new behaviour where the old one happens. They let people try it in a low-stakes way before they must commit. They shorten the distance between noticing and doing. In CLEAR terms, this is what the Leverage step is for: mapping the system to find the moments where attention is naturally present and placing the intervention there, instead of building a new channel and hoping attention follows.

5. What attention-first design looks like

Whether the setting is a shop, a screen or an office, the same design moves follow from taking attention seriously.

Reduce the competition before you add a cue

Most teams respond to low engagement by adding something: a sign, a banner, a reminder. The attention frame says to subtract first. Remove the three things that are consuming attention upstream of the behaviour, and the existing cue may start working on its own. Retailers do this with visual quiet zones around hero products. Product teams do it by cutting the number of choices on a page. Change leaders do it by cancelling competing initiatives, which is the least popular and most effective move available to them.

Put the behaviour within reach at the moment of attention

Attention decays fast. A cue that wins attention but requires the person to go somewhere else to act wastes most of what it won. The product must be graspable from where the eye landed. The button must be on the screen that raised the interest. The new process must be launchable from inside the old workflow.

Extend dwell, do not just capture it

Capturing attention is a moment. Purchasing, converting and adopting need duration. Touch matters because it stretches the moment into seconds. The digital and organisational equivalents are interaction: a configurator to play with, a sandbox to try, a pilot to join. Anything that gives the hands something to do while the mind decides.

Measure attention, not just outcomes

If attention is the gating resource, it should be the first thing measured. Retail has eye tracking and touch counts. Digital has scroll depth, dwell, hover and interaction rates. Organisations mostly have nothing, and it shows: they measure adoption at the end and cannot tell whether the failure was

awareness, interest or ability. Instrumenting attention turns a vague "people did not engage" into a specific, solvable problem.

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6. Objections

"Attention is just awareness, and awareness is the easy part." Awareness is a state; attention is a resource with a budget. Most change failures happen among people who were aware. They knew about the new system, the new offer, the new rule. What they never did was spend several uninterrupted seconds of processing on it at a moment when action was possible. Awareness without attention is a poster nobody reads twice.

"This is just marketing." Marketing is the discipline that has taken attention seriously the longest, which is why it has the best tools for it. The argument of this paper is that behavioural science and change management should stop treating attention as someone else's department.

"Some purchases are made without touching." True, and they are typically made with more attention elsewhere: reading reviews, comparing specifications, asking friends. The resource is still spent. It is simply spent through a different sense.

7. Conclusion

The customer who picks up the product and buys it is not a curiosity of retail psychology. She is a demonstration of the first law of behaviour change: nothing happens without attention, and attention is scarce. Every behavioural problem, from a cart abandoned to a policy ignored, should begin with the same question the shopkeeper asks. Can they see it? Can they reach it? Is anything standing in the way? Only when the answers are yes does it make sense to talk about motivation, incentives or persuasion. Design for attention first, and a surprising amount of the rest takes care of itself.

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